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LANGSTON HUGHES
1902–1967

Langston Hughes enjoys a special relationship to the Harlem Renaissance for two reasons above all. He helped define the spirit of the age, from a literary point of view, through his brilliant poetry and other writings during this era, in a career that continued to flourish when most of the other writers of the movement fell silent. He also left behind him, in a section of his autobiography *The Big Sea* (1940), the finest first-person account of the renaissance, a treasure-trove of impressions and memories on which virtually all scholars and students of the cultural movement have depended in their own writings.

Hughes was among the first of the writers and artists drawn to Harlem by its promise as a center of African American cultural activity. Born in Joplin, Missouri, Hughes had grown up in Lawrence, Kansas, and Lincoln, Illinois, before going to high school in Cleveland, Ohio, and spending a year in Mexico, near Mexico City. In all these places he was part of a small, sometimes tiny community of blacks, to whom he was nevertheless profoundly attached from early in his life. Hughes was descended from a distinguished family. His maternal grandmother's first husband had died at Harpers Ferry fighting in John Brown's band; her second husband, Langston's maternal grandfather, had been prominent in Kansas politics during Reconstruction, before racism drove him from the field; and his brother, John Mercer Langston, had been one of the most famous black Americans of the nineteenth century, a congressman from Virginia and the founding dean of the law school of Howard University. However, Hughes's mother, Carrie Langston Hughes, and his father, James N. Hughes, separated not long after his birth. His father emigrated to Mexico, where he was successful in business. In contrast, Langston grew up lonely and near poverty in Lawrence, Kansas.

In September 1921, aided by his father, he arrived in New York ostensibly to attend Columbia University but really, he later claimed, to see Harlem. The previous June, he had published one of his greatest poems, "The Negro Speaks of Rivers," in the *Crisis,* where his talent was immediately spotted by its brilliant literary editor, Jessie Fauset. Hughes lasted only one year at Columbia, where he did well but never felt comfortable. He took a succession of odd jobs, including stints as a delivery boy, vegetable farmer, and mess boy on a ship anchored up the Hudson River. In 1923, he sailed to Africa as a member of the crew of a merchant steamer; the following year he traveled the same way to Europe, where he jumped ship and spent several months in Paris working in the kitchen of a nightclub. Through all these jobs and adventures, Hughes continued to work on his poetry, which he published mainly in the *Crisis.* By 1924, his poetry showed the powerful influence of the blues and jazz. In fact, his poem "The Weary Blues" helped launch his career when it won first prize in the poetry section of the 1925 literary contest organized by *Opportunity* magazine. Aided enthusiastically by Carl Van Vechten, who remained a friend all of Hughes's life, he won a book contract from Knopf and published *The Weary Blues,* his first collection of verse, in 1926.

Although Hughes's earliest influences as a mature poet came from Walt Whitman and Carl Sandburg ("my guiding star"), Claude McKay stood for him in the early 1920s as the embodiment of the cosmopolitan and yet racially confident and committed black poet Hughes hoped to be. Hughes was also indebted to older figures such as Du Bois and James Weldon Johnson, both of whom admired his work and aided him. Images and sentiments such as that in "Poem" ("The night is beauti-

ful, / So the faces of my people") and "Dream Variations" ("Night coming tenderly / Black like me.") endeared his work to a wide range of African Americans, for whom he delighted in writing. His major step, encouraged in part by Sandburg's example (in publishing poems about jazz) but anchored by his own near-worship of black music as the major form of art within the race, was his adaptation of traditional poetic forms first to jazz, then to the blues, in which Hughes sometimes used dialect but in a way radically different from that of earlier writers. In these steps Hughes was well served by his early experimentation with a loose form of rhyme that frequently gave way to an inventively rhythmic free verse ("Me an' ma baby's / Got two mo' ways, / Two mo' ways to do de buck!"). His landmark poem "The Weary Blues" was the first by any poet to make use of the basic blues form.

Even more radical experimentation with the blues form led to his next collection, *Fine Clothes to the Jew* (1927). Among his most distinctive books, *Fine Clothes* was also his least successful in terms of sales and, in the black press (though not the white), its critical reception. Several reviewers in black newspapers and magazines were distressed by Hughes's fearless and, to them, tasteless evocation of elements of lower-class black culture, including its sometimes raw eroticism, never before treated in serious poetry. The book was "about 100 pages of trash [reeking] of the gutter and sewer," wrote one man; another found the poems "insanitary, insipid and repulsing." These reviewers probably gave *Fine Clothes to the Jew* a harsher reception than that ever accorded any other book of American poetry, with the exception of Whitman's *Leaves of Grass*.

In response to his critics, Hughes was adamant about his determination to write about such people and to experiment with blues and jazz. The year before, 1926, he had published in the *Nation* an essay in defense of the freedom of the black writer, "The Negro Artist and the Racial Mountain." "We younger Negro artists who create now intend to express our individual dark-skinned selves without fear or shame," he had declared. "We know we are beautiful. And ugly too." This essay quickly became a manifesto for many of the younger writers who also wished to assert their right to explore and exploit allegedly degraded aspects of black life. With most of these writers Hughes enjoyed a warm relationship; his modesty was matched by habits of generosity that endeared him to others.

Also in 1926, Hughes returned to school, this time at the historically black (although the faculty was almost entirely white) Lincoln University in Pennsylvania, from which he graduated in 1929. In 1927, his life took an extraordinary turn when he met Charlotte Osgood Mason, a wealthy, white patron of the arts then in her seventies, who had been led to Hughes by Alain Locke. In the next three years, Mason, who believed passionately in parapsychology, intuition, and folk culture, dominated Hughes's life with her gifts of money and her powerful advice about virtually every aspect of his life and art. She was directly involved in supervising the writing of his 1930 novel *Not without Laughter*, in which Hughes drew on his boyhood in Kansas to depict the life of a black child, Sandy, growing up in a representative midwestern African American home.

In 1930, in a dispute that involved Zora Neale Hurston, who was also being supported by Mason, the relationship between Hughes and his patron came to an explosive end. Hurt and baffled by Mason's rejection, in 1931 Hughes used money from a prize to spend several weeks recovering in Haiti. When he returned to the United States, he made a sharp turn toward the political left, although social and political consciousness, and an interest in socialism, had always been one feature of his verse. He published verse and essays in *New Masses*, a journal controlled by the Communist Party, and later that year began a tour of the South and the West designed to take poetry to the people, with Hughes reading his poems in churches and schools. In 1932, at the end of the tour, he boarded a ship in New York and sailed for the Soviet Union with a band of young African Americans invited to take part in a film about American race relations. For Hughes, the renaissance was long over, replaced by a sense of the need for political struggle and for an art that reflected this radical approach.

Unlike most of the writers of the renaissance, Hughes's career easily survived the end of that movement; there was never a year, or even a month or a week, when he did not produce art in keeping with his sense of himself as a thoroughly professional writer. In 1934, he published his first collection of short stories, the often acerbic and even embittered *The Ways of White Folks*. However, in the 1930s Hughes's main concern was probably the theater. His drama of miscegenation and the South, *Mulatto* (1935), became the longest running play by an African American on Broadway until Lorraine Hansberry's *A Raisin in the Sun* in the 1960s. Some of these plays were comedies, others were dramas of domestic African American life or were radical in their politics, as with Hughes's *Don't You Want to Be Free?* which his Harlem Suitcase Theater staged in 1938.

With the start of World War II, Hughes returned to the political center. His first book of autobiography, *The Big Sea*, with its memorable portrait of the renaissance, appeared in 1940. In poetry, he revived his interest in some of his old themes and forms, including the blues, as in the verse collection *Shakespeare in Harlem* (1942). In 1943, in his weekly column for the Chicago *Defender*, he introduced one of his enduring fictional triumphs, the character Jesse B. Semple, or Simple, a Harlem everyman whose comic manner hardly obscured some of the serious themes raised by Hughes in relating Simple's exploits. In 1947, as lyricist for the Broadway musical *Street Scene*, with music by Kurt Weill, Hughes earned enough money to purchase a house in his beloved Harlem, where he lived for the rest of his life.

His output became prodigious. In addition to books of verse, including the bebop-shaped *Montage of a Dream Deferred* (1951), a suite (gathering many of Hughes's best-known short poems, such as "Ballad of the Landlord," "Dream Boogie," "Harlem," "Motto," and "Theme for English B") about a changing Harlem, fertile with humanity but in decline, he published another volume of autobiography, two more volumes of short stories, a second novel, about a dozen books for children, five books drawn from the Simple columns (which ran for twenty years), several plays and musicals (including pioneering examples of the gospel musical), a history of the NAACP, various libretti for operas and cantatas, and landmark anthologies of African American writing (notably *Poetry of the Negro*, 1949) and of African literature.

By the end of his life Hughes was almost everywhere recognized, because of his versatility and skill, as the most representative writer in the history of African American literature and also as probably the most original of all black American poets. He cherished and even encouraged the often-bestowed title of "Poet Laureate of the Negro Race," which captures the importance he placed on writing literature both about and for African Americans as well as the sense that he had accomplished the central goal of his life with almost unrivaled success. Maturing in the Harlem Renaissance, Hughes's career demonstrates the solidity of that movement as the main foundation of modern African American literature.

The Negro Speaks of Rivers

I've known rivers:
I've known rivers ancient as the world and older than the
    flow of human blood in human veins.

My soul has grown deep like the rivers.

I bathed in the Euphrates when dawns were young.
I built my hut near the Congo and it lulled me to sleep. 5
I looked upon the Nile and raised the pyramids above it.
I heard the singing of the Mississippi when Abe Lincoln

went down to New Orleans,[1] and I've seen its muddy
bosom turn all golden in the sunset.

I've known rivers:
Ancient, dusky rivers.

My soul has grown deep like the rivers. 10

1921

Mother to Son

Well, son, I'll tell you:
Life for me ain't been no crystal stair.
It's had tacks in it,
And splinters,
And boards torn up, 5
And places with no carpet on the floor—
Bare.
But all the time
I'se been a-climbin' on,
And reachin' landin's, 10
And turnin' corners,
And sometimes goin' in the dark
Where there ain't been no light.
So boy, don't you turn back.
Don't you set down on the steps 15
'Cause you finds it's kinder hard.
Don't you fall now—
For I'se still goin', honey,
I'se still climbin',
And life for me ain't been no crystal stair. 20

1922

Danse Africaine

The low beating of the tom-toms,
The slow beating of the tom-toms,
  Low . . . slow
  Slow . . . low—
  Stirs your blood. 5
    Dance!
A night-veiled girl
  Whirls softly into a
  Circle of light.
  Whirls softly . . . slowly, 10
Like a wisp of smoke around the fire—
  And the tom-toms beat,

1. Lincoln's determination to end slavery was said to have started when, as a young man, he visited New Orleans for the first time.

And let that page come out of you—
Then, it will be true. 5

I wonder if it's that simple?
I am twenty-two, colored, born in Winston-Salem.
I went to school there, then Durham,[1] then here
to this college[2] on the hill above Harlem.
I am the only colored student in my class. 10
The steps from the hill lead down into Harlem,
through a park, then I cross St. Nicholas,
Eighth Avenue, Seventh, and I come to the Y,
the Harlem Branch Y, where I take the elevator
up to my room, sit down, and write this page: 15

It's not easy to know what is true for you or me
at twenty-two, my age. But I guess I'm what
I feel and see and hear, Harlem, I hear you:
hear you, hear me—we two—you, me, talk on this page.
(I hear New York, too.) Me—who? 20
Well, I like to eat, sleep, drink, and be in love.
I like to work, read, learn, and understand life.
I like a pipe for a Christmas present,
or records—Bessie, bop, or Bach.[3]
I guess being colored doesn't make me *not* like 25
the same things other folks like who are other races.
So will my page be colored that I write?
Being me, it will not be white.
But it will be
a part of you, instructor. 30
You are white—
yet a part of me, as I am a part of you.
That's American.
Sometimes perhaps you don't want to be a part of me.
Nor do I often want to be a part of you. 35
But we are, that's true!
As I learn from you,
I guess you learn from me—
although you're older—and white—
and somewhat more free. 40

This is my page for English B.

1949

The Negro Artist and the Racial Mountain[1]

One of the most promising of the young Negro poets said to me once, "I want to be a poet—not a Negro poet," meaning, I believe, "I want to write

1. Winston-Salem and Durham are cities in North Carolina.
2. City College of New York.
3. Johann Sebastain Bach (1688–1750). German composer and musician. Bessie Smith (1894–1937) blues singer. "Bop": jazz music of the 1940s, characterized by the use of discord and dissonance.

1. This essay originally appeared in *The Nation* in response to George S. Schuyler's essay "The Negro-Art Hokum," which was printed in *The Nation* the previous week.

like a white poet"; meaning subconsciously, "I would like to be a white poet"; meaning behind that, "I would like to be white." And I was sorry the young man said that, for no great poet has ever been afraid of being himself. And I doubted then that, with his desire to run away spiritually from his race, this boy would ever be a great poet. But this is the mountain standing in the way of any true Negro art in America—this urge within the race toward whiteness, the desire to pour racial individuality into the mold of American standardization, and to be as little Negro and as much American as possible.

But let us look at the immediate background of this young poet. His family is of what I suppose one would call the Negro middle class: people who are by no means rich yet never uncomfortable nor hungry—smug, contented, respectable folk, members of the Baptist church. The father goes to work every morning. He is a chief steward at a large white club. The mother sometimes does fancy sewing or supervises parties for the rich families of the town. The children go to a mixed school. In the home they read white papers and magazines. And the mother often says "Don't be like niggers" when the children are bad. A frequent phrase from the father is, "Look how well a white man does things." And so the word white comes to be unconsciously a symbol of all virtues. It holds for the children beauty, morality, and money. The whisper of "I want to be white" runs silently through their minds. This young poet's home is, I believe, a fairly typical home of the colored middle class. One sees immediately how difficult it would be for an artist born in such a home to interest himself in interpreting the beauty of his own people. He is never taught to see that beauty. He is taught rather not to see it, or if he does, to be ashamed of it when it is not according to Caucasian patterns.

For racial culture the home of a self-styled "high-class" Negro has nothing better to offer. Instead there will perhaps be more aping of things white than in a less cultured or less wealthy home. The father is perhaps a doctor, lawyer, landowner, or politician. The mother may be a social worker, or a teacher, or she may do nothing and have a maid. Father is often dark but he has usually married the lightest woman he could find. The family attend a fashionable church where few really colored faces are to be found. And they themselves draw a color line. In the North they go to white theaters and white movies. And in the South they have at least two cars and a house "like white folks." Nordic manners, Nordic faces, Nordic hair, Nordic art (if any), and an Episcopal heaven. A very high mountain indeed for the would-be racial artist to climb in order to discover himself and his people.

But then there are the low-down folks, the so-called common element, and they are the majority—may the Lord be praised! The people who have their hip of gin on Saturday nights and are not too important to themselves or the community, or too well fed, or too learned to watch the lazy world go round. They live on Seventh Street in Washington or State Street in Chicago and they do not particularly care whether they are like white folks or anybody else. Their joy runs, bang! into ecstasy. Their religion soars to a shout. Work maybe a little today, rest a little tomorrow. Play awhile. Sing awhile. O, let's dance! These common people are not afraid of spirituals, as for a long time their more intellectual brethren were, and jazz is their child. They furnish a wealth of colorful, distinctive material for any artist because they still hold their own individuality in the face of American standardizations. And perhaps these common people will give to the world its truly great Negro artist, the one who is not afraid to be himself. Whereas the better-

class Negro would tell the artist what to do, the people at least let him alone when he does appear. And they are not ashamed of him—if they know he exists at all. And they accept what beauty is their own without question.

Certainly there is, for the American Negro artist who can escape the restrictions the more advanced among his own group would put upon him, a great field of unused material ready for his art. Without going outside his race, and even among the better classes with their "white" culture and conscious American manners, but still Negro enough to be different, there is sufficient matter to furnish a black artist with a lifetime of creative work. And when he chooses to touch on the relations between Negroes and whites in this country with their innumerable overtones and undertones surely, and especially for literature and the drama, there is an inexhaustible supply of themes at hand. To these the Negro artist can give his racial individuality, his heritage of rhythm and warmth, and his incongruous humor that so often, as in the Blues, becomes ironic laughter mixed with tears. But let us look again at the mountain.

A prominent Negro clubwoman in Philadelphia paid eleven dollars to hear Raquel Meller sing Andalusian[2] popular songs. But she told me a few weeks before she would not think of going to hear "that woman," Clara Smith,[3] a great black artist, sing Negro folksongs. And many an upper-class Negro church, even now, would not dream of employing a spiritual in its services. The drab melodies in white folks' hymnbooks are much to be preferred. "We want to worship the Lord correctly and quietly. We don't believe in 'shouting.' Let's be dull like the Nordics," they say, in effect.

The road for the serious black artist, then, who would produce a racial art is most certainly rocky and the mountain is high. Until recently he received almost no encouragement for his work from either white or colored people. The fine novels of Chesnutt[4] go out of print with neither race noticing their passing. The quaint charm and humor of Dunbar's[5] dialect verse brought to him, in his day, largely the same kind of encouragement one would give a sideshow freak (A colored man writing poetry! How odd!) or a clown (How amusing!).

The present vogue in things Negro, although it may do as much harm as good for the budding colored artist, has at least done this: it has brought him forcibly to the attention of his own people among whom for so long, unless the other race had noticed him beforehand, he was a prophet with little honor. I understand that Charles Gilpin[6] acted for years in Negro theaters without any special acclaim from his own, but when Broadway gave him eight curtain calls, Negroes, too, began to beat a tin pan in his honor. I know a young colored writer, a manual worker by day, who had been writing well for the colored magazines for some years, but it was not until he recently broke into the white publications and his first book was accepted by a prominent New York publisher that the "best" Negroes in his city took the trouble to discover that he lived there. Then almost immediately they decided to give a grand dinner for him. But the society ladies were careful

2. From a region of Spain.
3. Major blues singer (1885–1935).
4. Charles Chesnutt (1858–1932), author of three novels, *The House behind the Cedars* (1900), *The Marrow of Tradition* (1901), and *The Colonel's Dream* (1905); a biography of Frederick Douglass; and two short story collections, *The Conjure Woman* (1899) and *The Wife of His Youth and Other Stories of the Color Line* (1899).
5. Paul Laurence Dunbar (1872–1906), poet and author of the novel *Sport of the Gods* (1907).
6. American actor (1878–1930).

to whisper to his mother that perhaps she'd better not come. They were not sure she would have an evening gown.[7]

The Negro artist works against an undertow of sharp criticism and misunderstanding from his own group and unintentional bribes from the whites. "Oh, be respectable, write about nice people, show how good we are," say the Negroes. "Be stereotyped, don't go too far, don't shatter our illusions about you, don't amuse us too seriously. We will pay you," say the whites. Both would have told Jean Toomer not to write *Cane*.[8] The colored people did not praise it. The white people did not buy it. Most of the colored people who did read *Cane* hate it. They are afraid of it. Although the critics gave it good reviews the public remained indifferent. Yet (excepting the work of Du Bois[9]), *Cane* contains the finest prose written by a Negro in America. And like the singing of Robeson,[1] it is truly racial.

But in spite of the Nordicized Negro intelligentsia and the desires of some white editors we have an honest American Negro literature already with us. Now I await the rise of the Negro theater. Our folk music, having achieved world-wide fame, offers itself to the genius of the great individual American composer who is to come. And within the next decade I expect to see the work of a growing school of colored artists who paint and model the beauty of dark faces and create with new technique the expressions of their own soul-world. And the Negro dancers who will dance like flame and the singers who will continue to carry our songs to all who listen—they will be with us in even greater numbers tomorrow.

Most of my own poems are racial in theme and treatment, derived from the life I know. In many of them I try to grasp and hold some of the meanings and rhythms of jazz. I am as sincere as I know how to be in these poems and yet after every reading I answer questions like these from my own people: Do you think Negroes should always write about Negroes? I wish you wouldn't read some of your poems to white folks. How do you find anything interesting in a place like a cabaret? Why do you write about black people? You aren't black. What makes you do so many jazz poems?

But jazz to me is one of the inherent expressions of Negro life in America; the eternal tom-tom beating in the Negro soul—the tom-tom of revolt against weariness in a white world, a world of subway trains, and work, work, work; the tom-tom of joy and laughter, and pain swallowed in a smile. Yet the Philadelphia clubwoman is ashamed to say that her race created it and she does not like me to write about it. The old subconscious "white is best" runs through her mind. Years of study under white teachers, a lifetime of white books, pictures, and papers, and white manners, morals, and Puritan standards made her dislike the spirituals. And now she turns up her nose at jazz and all its manifestations—likewise almost everything else distinctly racial. She doesn't care for the Winold Reiss[2] portraits of Negroes because they are "too Negro." She does not want a true picture of herself from anybody. She wants the artist to flatter her, to make the white world believe that all Negroes are as smug and as near white in soul as she wants to be. But, to my

7. This incident, which happened to Hughes himself in 1925, is related in his autobiography *The Big Sea* (1940).
8. A collection (1923) of stories, poetry, and drama about the rural South and the urban North.
9. W. E. B. Du Bois (1868–1963) helped found the NAACP and edited its journal, *Crisis*, from 1910 to 1934; he is best known for *The Souls of Black Folk* (1903).
1. Paul Robeson (1898–1976), actor and singer.
2. Portrait painter (1886–1953).

mind, it is the duty of the younger Negro artist, if he accepts any duties at all from outsiders, to change through the force of his art that old whispering "I want to be white," hidden in the aspirations of his people, to "Why should I want to be white? I am a Negro—and beautiful!"

So I am ashamed for the black poet who says, "I want to be a poet, not a Negro poet," as though his own racial world were not as interesting as any other world. I am ashamed, too, for the colored artist who runs from the painting of Negro faces to the painting of sunsets after the manner of the academicians because he fears the strange un-whiteness of his own features. An artist must be free to choose what he does, certainly, but he must also never be afraid to do what he might choose.

Let the blare of Negro jazz bands and the bellowing voice of Bessie Smith[3] singing Blues penetrate the closed ears of the colored nearintellectuals until they listen and perhaps understand. Let Paul Robeson singing "Water Boy," and Rudolph Fisher writing about the streets of Harlem, and Jean Toomer holding the heart of Georgia in his hands, and Aaron Douglas[4] drawing strange black fantasies cause the smug Negro middle class to turn from their white, respectable, ordinary books and papers to catch a glimmer of their own beauty. We younger Negro artists who create now intend to express our individual dark-skinned selves without fear or shame. If white people are pleased we are glad. If they are not, it doesn't matter. We know we are beautiful. And ugly too. The tom-tom cries and the tom-tom laughs. If colored people are pleased we are glad. If they are not, their displeasure doesn't matter either. We build our temples for tomorrow, strong as we know how, and we stand on top of the mountain, free within ourselves.

1926

From The Big Sea

When the Negro Was in Vogue

The 1920's were the years of Manhattan's black Renaissance. It began with *Shuffle Along, Running Wild,* and the Charleston.[1] Perhaps some people would say even with *The Emperor Jones,* Charles Gilpin, and the tom-toms at the Provincetown.[2] But certainly it was the musical revue, *Shuffle Along,* that gave a scintillating send-off to that Negro vogue in Manhattan, which reached its peak just before the crash of 1929, the crash that sent Negroes, white folks, and all rolling down the hill toward the Works Progress Administration.[3]

Shuffle Along was a honey of a show. Swift, bright, funny, rollicking, and gay, with a dozen danceable, singable tunes. Besides, look who were in it:

3. Blues singer (1894–1937).
4. Artist and educator (1899–1979). Fisher (1897–1934), author of two novels, *The Walls of Jericho* (1928) and *The Conjure Man Dies* (1932).
1. A popular dance that swept the nation in the 1920s. *Shuffle Along,* a 1921 musical comedy created by Flournoy Miller, Aubrey Lyles, Eubie Blake, and Noble Sissle, was a tremendous success in New York. *Runnin' Wild,* another musical revue by Miller and Lyles, is often credited with introducing New York to the Charleston in 1923.
2. I.e., the Provincetown Playhouse. *The Emperor Jones,* by white playwright Eugene O'Neill, premiered in 1920. Gilpin (1878–1930), black actor, had the title role.
3. One of Franklin Roosevelt's programs for economic recovery from the Great Depression. "Crash of 1929": the stock market crash that ushered in the Depression.